is authoritative, however, we must confront those issues in this case.[29]

Our decisions establish with unmistakable clarity that the freedom of an individual to associate for the purpose of advancing beliefs and ideas is protected by the First and Fourteenth Amendments. *E. g., Elrod* v. *Burns,* 427 U. S. 347, 355–357 (plurality opinion); *Cousins* v. *Wigoda,* 419 U. S. 477, 487; *Kusper* v. *Pontikes,* 414 U. S. 51, 56–57; *NAACP* v. *Alabama ex rel. Patterson,* 357 U. S. 449, 460–461.

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[29] In *Lathrop* v. *Donohue,* 367 U. S. 820, a companion case to *Street,* a lawyer sued for the refund of dues paid (under protest) to the integrated Wisconsin State Bar. The dues were required as a condition of practicing law in Wisconsin. The plaintiff contended that the requirement violated his constitutionally protected freedom of association because the dues were used by the State Bar to formulate and to support legislative proposals concerning the legal profession to which the plaintiff objected.

A plurality of four Justices found that the requirement was not on its face unconstitutional, relying on the analogy to *Hanson.* And the plurality ruled, as had the Court in *Hanson,* that the constitutional questions tendered were not ripe, for the Court was nowhere "clearly apprised as to the views of the appellant on any particular legislative issues on which the State Bar has taken a position, or as to the way in which and the degree to which funds compulsorily exacted from its members are used to support the organization's political activities." 367 U. S., at 845–846. The other five Members of the Court disagreed with the plurality and thought that the constitutional questions ought to be reached. Three Justices would have upheld the constitutionality of using compulsory dues to finance the State Bar's legislative activities even where opposed by dissenting members. See *id.,* at 848 (Harlan, J., concurring in judgment); *id.,* at 865 (Whittaker, J., concurring in result). The other two Justices would have held such activities to be unconstitutional. See *ibid.* (Black, J., dissenting); *id.,* at 877 (Douglas, J., dissenting).

The only proposition about which a majority of the Court in *Lathrop* agreed was that the constitutional issues should be reached. However, due to the disparate views of those five Justices on the merits and the failure of the other four Members of the Court to discuss the constitutional questions, *Lathrop* does not provide a clear holding to guide us in adjudicating the constitutional questions here presented.